The Wondrous Feast



Harold lived a simple life despite growing up in a family of great wealth. When he left, he had vowed to renounce all extravagance. However, after many years away, he was pressured into returning home for Christmas, to the opulence he despised. He resigned himself to suffering through the lavish meals and the trappings of luxury.

Once at his family home, however, he was surprised to find himself enjoying the high cuisine. He was accustomed to a dinner consisting of a small cup of thin soup. Here, a servant would present a large urn overflowing with rich broth, and he would fill his bowl under the cascade. Instead of dry mackerel just on Friday, here he ate fish every night. Another servant would come by his seat and offer him a plate of what, when feathered, must have been an exotic bird; now it was an exquisite dish. True, the family dinners didn't have much in the way of vegetables, but lining the walls of the dining room were reproductions of still lives painted by Dutch masters, showing bowls filled with legumes.

The last meal of his visit was on Christmas Eve, and Harold was overcome with emotion. His heart burst into song at the sight of the servers and the bounty before him: Waterfall consommé, the nightly cod, the offer last in feather, the prints of peas! He would soon return to his plain eating, but for now, Hallelujah!

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